

Is it time to do away with IPL mega auctions?

Many franchises feel that holding a mega auction every three years **disrupts momentum** and undermines long-term team-building efforts.

Shayan Acharya

shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

On a rainy July evening at the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) headquarters in Mumbai, the owners of the 10 Indian Premier League (IPL) franchises gathered for one of their longest meetings to date. As it drizzled outside, intense debates ensued over the retention policy for players going forward.

While at least three franchises favoured scrapping the mega auction held every three years in favour of more player retention, others disagreed. By the end of the six-hour meeting, the exhausted expressions on the faces of the owners and BCCI office-bearers revealed the outcome: no consensus had been reached.

Following the meeting, the BCCI announced the retention rules for the next three-year cycle, starting from 2025. **Under these new guidelines, each team is allowed to retain six players from its previous squad, with a maximum of five capped internationals — Indian or overseas — and up to two uncapped Indian players.** However, the debates surrounding the policy continue.

While not many have come on record, a common sentiment is that the BCCI should finalise retention policies for future cycles as early as possible. "This time, we had to wait until the end of September to know the retention rules, which forced us to scramble," said a senior franchise official, adding, "If we get some more time, it makes life easier for everyone. That's something we need to consider going forward."

Many franchises feel that holding a mega auction every three years disrupts momentum and undermines long-term team-building efforts. "It takes a lot of time to build a squad, and it also takes significant time and investment for younger players to mature," said Sunrisers Hyderabad owner Kavya Maran. The franchise has invested in developing talents like Abhishek Sharma, who needed three years to become a consistent performer. Maran's sentiments resonated with other franchises, including defending champion Kolkata Knight Riders and inaugural season winner Rajasthan Royals, both of whom opted for full retention of six players.

Five teams — Chennai Super Kings, Gujarat Titans, Lucknow Super

Major overhaul: Kolkata Knight Riders and Delhi Capitals have released Shreyas Iyer and Rishabh Pant, respectively, ahead of this year's IPL mega auction. K. R. DEEPAK